Mark Scheme (Results)

Summer 2026

Pearson Edexcel GCSE
In History (1HI0)
Paper P4 Period study

Option P4 Superpower relations and the Cold War,1941-91

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General Marking Guidance

- All candidates must receive the same treatment. Examiners must mark the first candidate in exactly the same way as they mark the last.
- Mark schemes should be applied positively. Candidates must be rewarded for what they have shown they can do rather than penalised for omissions.
- Examiners should mark according to the mark scheme not according to their perception of where the grade boundaries may lie.
- There is no ceiling on achievement. All marks on the mark scheme should be used appropriately.
- All the marks on the mark scheme are designed to be awarded. Examiners should always award full marks if deserved, i.e. if the answer matches the mark scheme. Examiners should also be prepared to award zero marks if the candidate's response is not worthy of credit according to the mark scheme.
- Where some judgement is required, mark schemes will provide the principles by which marks will be awarded and exemplification may be limited.
- When examiners are in doubt regarding the application of the mark scheme to a candidate's response, the team leader must be consulted.
- Crossed out work should be marked UNLESS the candidate has replaced it with an alternative response.

How to award marks when level descriptions are used

1. **Finding the right level**

The first stage is to decide which level the answer should be placed in. To do this, use a 'best-fit' approach, deciding which level most closely describes the quality of the answer. Answers can display characteristics from more than one level, and where this happens markers must use the guidance below and their professional judgement to decide which level is most appropriate. For example, one stronger passage at L4 would not by itself merit a L4 mark, but it might be evidence to support a high L3 mark, unless there are substantial weaknesses in other areas. Similarly, an answer that fits best in L3 but which has some characteristics of L2 might be placed at the bottom of L3. An answer displaying some characteristics of L3 and some of L1 might be placed in L2.

2. **Finding a mark within a level**

After a level has been decided on, the next stage is to decide on the mark within the level. The instructions below tell you how to reward responses within a level. However, where a level has specific guidance about how to place an answer within a level, always follow that guidance.

Levels containing two marks only

Start with the presumption that the work will be at the top of the level. Move down to the lower mark if the work only just meets the requirements of the level.

Levels containing three or more marks

Markers should be prepared to use the full range of marks available in a level and not restrict marks to the middle. Markers should start at the middle of the level (or the upper-middle mark if there is an even number of marks) and then move the mark up or down to find the best mark. To do this, they should take into account how far the answer meets the requirements of the level:

- If it meets the requirements *fully*, markers should be prepared to award full marks within the level. The top mark in the level is used for answers that are as good as can realistically be expected within that level.
- If it only *barely* meets the requirements of the level, markers should consider awarding marks at the bottom of the level. The bottom mark in the level is used for answers that are the weakest that can be expected within that level.
- The middle marks of the level are used for answers that have a *reasonable* match to the descriptor. This might represent a balance between some characteristics of the level that are fully met and others that are only barely met.

Indicative content

Examiners are reminded that indicative content is provided as an illustration to markers of some of the material that may be offered by students. It does not show required content and alternatives should be credited where valid.

P4 Period study: Superpower relations and the Cold War, 1941–91

Question		
1(a)		Explain **one** consequence of the Potsdam Conference (July–August 1945). **Target**: Analysis of second order concepts: consequence [AO2]; Knowledge and understanding of features and characteristics [AO1]. **AO2**: 4 marks. **AO1**: 4 marks. **NB** mark each consequence separately (2 x 4 marks).
Level	**Mark**	**Descriptor**
	0	No rewardable material.
1	**1–2**	• Simple or generalised comment is offered about a consequence. [AO2] • Generalised information about the topic is included, showing limited knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1]
2	**3–4**	• Features of the period are analysed to explain a consequence. [AO2] • Specific information about the topic is added to support the explanation, showing good knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1]

Marking instructions

Markers must apply the descriptors above in line with the general marking guidance (page 3).

Performance in AO1 and AO2 is interdependent. An answer displaying **no** qualities of AO2 cannot be awarded more than the top of Level 1, no matter how strong performance is in AO1; markers should note that the expectation for AO1 is that candidates demonstrate both knowledge *and* understanding.

Indicative content guidance

Answers must be credited according to candidates' deployment of material in relation to the qualities outlined in the mark scheme. While specific references are made in the indicative content below, this does not imply that these must be included; other relevant material must also be credited.

Relevant points may include:

- The Potsdam Conference led to the division of Germany into four zones of occupation by the USSR, the USA, Britain and France.
- The Potsdam Conference led to disagreements on how severely to punish Germany, with Stalin wanting more reparations paid to the USSR.
- Truman's decision to inform Stalin at Potsdam that the USA had successfully developed the atomic bomb led to increasing tension between the superpowers.

Question		
1(b)		Explain **one** consequence of the construction of the Berlin Wall (1961). **Target**: Analysis of second order concepts: consequence [AO2]; Knowledge and understanding of features and characteristics [AO1]. **AO2**: 4 marks. **AO1**: 4 marks. **NB** mark each consequence separately (2 x 4 marks).
Level	**Mark**	**Descriptor**
	0	No rewardable material.
1	**1–2**	• Simple or generalised comment is offered about a consequence. [AO2] • Generalised information about the topic is included, showing limited knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1]
2	**3–4**	• Features of the period are analysed to explain a consequence. [AO2] • Specific information about the topic is added to support the explanation, showing good knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1]

Marking instructions

Markers must apply the descriptors above in line with the general marking guidance (page 3).

Performance in AO1 and AO2 is interdependent. An answer displaying **no** qualities of AO2 cannot be awarded more than the top of Level 1, no matter how strong performance is in AO1; markers should note that the expectation for AO1 is that candidates demonstrate both knowledge *and* understanding.

Indicative content guidance

Answers must be credited according to candidates' deployment of material in relation to the qualities outlined in the mark scheme. While specific references are made in the indicative content below, this does not imply that these must be included; other relevant material must also be credited.

Relevant points may include:

- The construction of the Berlin Wall allowed East Germany's economy to develop, as it ended the flow of refugees from East to West Germany.
- The construction of the Berlin Wall became a famous symbol of the division of Europe and led to Kennedy visiting West Berlin and making a speech criticising communism.
- The construction of the Berlin Wall led to the division of German families and friends as it was now almost impossible to cross from East to West Berlin.

<table>
<tr><th colspan="2">Question</th><th></th></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">2</td><td>Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Cold War crisis over Cuba in the years 1961-62.

You may use the following in your answer:
• the Bay of Pigs (1961)
• Soviet nuclear missile sites in Cuba
You must also use information of your own.

Target: Analytical narrative (i.e. analysis of causation/consequence/change) [AO2]; Knowledge and understanding of features and characteristics) [AO1].
AO2: 4 marks.
AO1: 4 marks.</td></tr>
<tr><th>Level</th><th>Mark</th><th>Descriptor</th></tr>
<tr><td></td><td>0</td><td>No rewardable material.</td></tr>
<tr><td>1</td><td>1–2</td><td>• A simple or generalised narrative is provided; the account shows limited analysis and organisation of the events included. [AO2]
• Limited knowledge and understanding of the events is shown. [AO1]</td></tr>
<tr><td>2</td><td>3–5</td><td>• A narrative is given, showing some organisation of material into a sequence of events leading to an outcome. The account of events shows some analysis of the linkage between them, but some passages of the narrative may lack coherence and organisation. [AO2]
• Accurate and relevant information is added, showing some knowledge and understanding of the events. [AO1]</td></tr>
<tr><td>3</td><td>6–8</td><td>• A narrative is given which organises material into a clear sequence of events leading to an outcome. The account of events analyses the linkage between them and is coherent and logically structured. [AO2]
• Accurate and relevant information is included, showing good knowledge and understanding of the key features or characteristics of the events. [AO1]
No access to Level 3 for answers that do not address three or more aspects of content.</td></tr>
</table>

Marking instructions

Markers must apply the descriptors above in line with the general marking guidance (page 3).

Performance in AO1 and AO2 is interdependent. An answer displaying no qualities of AO2 cannot be awarded more than the top of Level 1, no matter how strong performance is in AO1; markers should note that the expectation for AO1 is that candidates demonstrate both knowledge and understanding.

The middle mark in Levels 2 and 3 may be achieved by stronger performance in either AO1 or AO2.

Indicative content guidance

Answers must be credited according to candidates' deployment of material in relation to the qualities outlined in the mark scheme. While specific references are made in the indicative content below, this does not imply that these must be included; other relevant material must also be credited.

Relevant points may include:

- With Cuba developing closer relations with the USSR, the USA felt the need to act and planned for Cuban exiles to be trained by the CIA to invade Cuba. Kennedy agreed to implement the plan to invade Cuba at the Bay of Pigs.
- The failure of the Bay of Pigs invasion was a humiliation for the USA and pushed Castro into seeking a closer alliance with the USSR.
- In October 1962, an American spy plane took photographs of nuclear missile sites being built by the USSR in Cuba, which led to President Kennedy setting up ExComm for advice on how to respond.
- President Kennedy was informed that Soviet ships carrying nuclear missiles were sailing towards Cuba and, as a result, he decided on a naval blockade of Cuba and told Khrushchev the Soviet convoy would be stopped.
- The Soviet ships approaching the blockade were ordered by Khrushchev to turn back to avoid confrontation, thus averting a direct nuclear confrontation.
- After thirteen days of crisis, Khrushchev agreed to remove the Cuban missiles in return for the USA agreeing not to invade Cuba while, in a secret agreement, President Kennedy committed to withdrawing US missiles from Turkey.

Question		
3		Explain **two** of the following: • The importance of the Berlin blockade (1948-49) for tension between East and West. • The importance of events in Czechoslovakia in 1968 for relations between East and West. • The importance of US President Reagan's actions for superpower relations in the 1980s. **Target**: Analysis of second order concepts: consequence/significance [AO2]; Knowledge and understanding of features and characteristics [AO1]. **AO2**: 8 marks. **AO1**: 8 marks. **NB** mark each part of the answer separately (2 x 8 marks).
Level	**Mark**	**Descriptor**
	0	No rewardable material.
1	1–2	• A simple or generalised answer is given, showing limited development and organisation of material. [AO2] • Limited knowledge and understanding of the topic is shown. [AO1]
2	3–5	• An explanation is given, showing an attempt to analyse importance. It shows some reasoning, but some passages may lack coherence and organisation. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is added, showing some knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1]
3	6–8	• An explanation is given, showing analysis of importance. It shows a line of reasoning that is coherent and logically structured. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is included, showing good knowledge and understanding of the required features or characteristics of the period studied. [AO1]

Marking instructions

Markers must apply the descriptors above in line with the general marking guidance (page 3).

Performance in AO1 and AO2 is interdependent. An answer displaying **no** qualities of AO2 cannot be awarded more than the top of Level 1, no matter how strong performance is in AO1a; markers should note that the expectation for AO1 is that candidates demonstrate both knowledge *and* understanding.

The middle mark in Levels 2 and 3 may be achieved by stronger performance in either AO1 or AO2.

Indicative content guidance

Answers must be credited according to candidates' deployment of material in relation to the qualities outlined in the mark scheme. While specific references are made in the indicative content below, this does not imply that these must be included; other relevant material must also be credited.

The importance of the Berlin blockade (1948–49) for tension between East and West.

Relevant points may include:

- Stalin's blockade of road, rail and canal routes into West Berlin, as a deliberate attempt to try to force the West to give up their sectors of Berlin, increased western fears of Soviet expansion.
- The USA's and Britain's response to the Berlin blockade with the Berlin Airlift frustrated Stalin, as it showed the West's determination not to abandon West Berlin.
- The failure of the Berlin blockade increased existing tensions between East and West and led to the more formal and permanent division of Germany, with the setting up of the FRG followed by the GDR.
- The 1948-49 crisis over Berlin reinforced the USA's commitment to western Europe and led to the formation of NATO, regarded by the USSR as an aggressive and hostile act by the West.

The importance of events in Czechoslovakia in 1968 for relations between East and West.

Relevant points may include:

- Reforms introduced by Dubcek during the Prague Spring, such as less censorship, encouraged the USA to make anti-communist radio broadcasts, which were seen by Brezhnev as a threat to Soviet control.
- The use of Soviet military force to end the Prague Spring was condemned by the USA and many Western governments, leading to a deterioration in relations between East and West.
- The USA was prepared to criticise the USSR and cancel an upcoming meeting planned between Johnson and Brezhnev, but there was an unwillingness by the West to take any further action that would lead to even more strained East-West relations.
- Relations worsened between East and West, as the events in Czechoslovakia were used by the USSR to strengthen its control over its satellite states with the introduction of the Brezhnev Doctrine.

The importance of US President Reagan's actions for superpower relations in the 1980s.

Relevant points may include:

- On becoming President, Reagan significantly increased US spending on arms, leading to new weapons such as Stealth bombers and Trident submarines, which alarmed Soviet leaders.
- Reagan calling the USSR 'the evil empire', and his announcement of the Strategic Defence Initiative ('Star Wars') threatened the USSR and led to worsening superpower relations.
- Reagan claimed the 'Second Cold War' was designed to force the USSR to improve relations with the USA as the weak Soviet economy could not compete with US defence spending.
- New attitudes over arms control developed, and Reagan attending a series of meetings with Gorbachev, led to reductions in nuclear weapons with the INF Treaty and an improvement in superpower relations.

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